The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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Four things happened this week that will still matter in five years. The House passed a defense bill carrying the largest rewrite of federal maritime law in decades. The Navy opened the market on the biggest single infrastructure project it has ever attempted, a dry dock at Puget Sound with a contract ceiling of $30 billion. The submarine industrial base finally got $76.6 billion after a three-year standoff, and a twelfth of that is aimed at people rather than steel. And at RIMPAC, a part was printed at sea, carried to a warship by an uncrewed boat, and installed, which is less interesting for the printing than for the software that decided where to print it.

Running underneath all four is one question: whether there are enough docks, enough suppliers, and enough trained people to do the work the country keeps authorizing. Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

The Navy opens the market on a $30 billion dry dock, before it has environmental clearance

FACT: the Navy announced on June 15, 2026 that NAVFAC Northwest had posted a Sources Sought announcement on SAM.gov for a Multi-Mission Dry Dock at Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility, and launched multimissiondrydock.com as the project's public repository, describing the dock under the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program as "the largest single infrastructure modernization project in Navy history." FACT: in that release Capt. Troy Brown, the accountable project officer, called it "day one of a multi-decade, critical infrastructure project for the Navy," and the Navy listed a scope running from dock drainage and dewatering systems to a caisson and caisson gate, rail networks, portal crane track and utility routing tunnels. FACT: the same release states the Navy is still working through the National Environmental Policy Act process, with the Final Environmental Impact Statement and Record of Decision expected later this year.

A Sources Sought notice is not a solicitation. It is the government asking the market who is capable and interested, before it writes the real terms, which is why it arrives this early.

FACT: Military Times reported on July 22, 2026 that the resulting multiple-award construction contract carries a ceiling of $30 billion, runs five years plus three one-year options, and breaks into task orders typically between $2 billion and $6 billion, with the work sited in existing Dry Dock 3 and Piers 6 and 7 and the second task order covering demolition of Dry Dock 3. FACT: the same report quotes the notice describing the dock as "a fully pressure-relieved dry dock," and quotes the Navy's project website stating that "the Navy does not currently have the capacity and capability to perform depot-level maintenance on a Gerald R. Ford-class carrier in the Pacific Northwest," and that "the only dry dock on the West Coast able to accommodate a current Nimitz-class aircraft carrier is Dry Dock 6 (DD6), which does not meet seismic resiliency standards and cannot fully accommodate Ford-class carriers."

"Pressure-relieved" is the engineering heart of it. A graving dock sits below the water table, so groundwater pushes up on the floor with enough force to crack it; a pressure-relieved dock drains that water away continuously instead of resisting it, which is what allows a deeper, longer dock on a waterfront like Bremerton's.

FACT: as dated context, GAO reported on June 28, 2023 (GAO-23-106067) that the estimated cost of the Navy's dry dock project at Portsmouth Naval Shipyard rose from $528 million to $2.2 billion between 2019 and 2021, that the Navy had trouble estimating project costs partly because estimates rested on preliminary rather than mature designs, and recommended the Navy update its estimates throughout the design process.

Assessment: three consequences follow, and only the first belongs to Puget Sound. Locally this is heavy construction inside a working yard, so demolishing one dock and reworking two piers takes capacity out of service for years while dredging and utility work constrains the waterfront around it. Nationally, a $30 billion ceiling with task orders of $2 billion to $6 billion concentrates the heavy-civil contractor pool and the NAVFAC execution capacity that every other yard's projects compete for, which makes scarcity of qualified constructors, not scarcity of authorization, the near-term schedule risk. And the GAO finding is the precedent to measure this against: a project scoped from preliminary design grew roughly fourfold, so the question worth asking about each task order is what design maturity its estimate rests on.

One sequencing note: the Navy is sounding the market on a project whose environmental clearance is not finished, which is normal, but it makes early schedule risk here regulatory as much as constructional.

> **Bottom line:** Watch three things: the design maturity behind each task order estimate, which regional constructors get consumed in the years other yards need them, and what the Record of Decision does to the first task order's start date.

Sources: Navy / NAVFAC Northwest via DVIDS, Jun 15, 2026; Military Times, Jul 22, 2026; GAO-23-106067, Jun 28, 2023

Deckplate: the wage fix worked, which is not the same as a motivated workforce

FACT: Rep. Joe Courtney, ranking member of the Seapower and Projection Forces Subcommittee, said in his June 4, 2026 markup statement that the FY27 bill provides full funding for shipyard wage improvement, and that such funding over the last three years "had a massive positive impact on labor contracts, shipyard recruitment and retention." FACT: USNI News reported on July 29, 2026 that $5 billion of the new submarine award is for workforce improvements between Electric Boat and HII, and that a major factor in the boats' rising prices is workforce shortage, with many experienced shipbuilders having retired and builders competing for labor against other industries.

Assessment: that is a real result and worth saying plainly, because pay complaints are the kind of problem that poisons everything else until it is fixed. It is also, on the evidence, only half of a workforce strategy. The vault's note on Herzberg's motivation-hygiene theory makes the useful distinction: the conditions *around* a job, including pay, supervision and working conditions, mostly determine how unhappy people are, while the things *inside* the work, achievement, responsibility, recognition and growth, are what create drive. Fixing pay moves a workforce from unhappy to neutral. It does not, by itself, move anyone to engaged.

The honest caveat travels with the theory, and that note carries it: Herzberg built the model by asking people to recall their best and worst days, which invites them to credit themselves for the good and blame their surroundings for the bad, and later work has not reproduced the clean split. Salary in particular shows up on both sides of his own chart, so "money never motivates" overstates it. Treat the two lists as a checklist rather than a law.

> **Bottom line:** If wage funding has closed your pay gap, the next retention gain will not come from pay, so measure why people actually leave, and check first-year attrition separately from overall attrition, because those two numbers usually have different causes.

Sources: Rep. Joe Courtney, FY27 NDAA markup statement, Jun 4, 2026; USNI News, Jul 29, 2026

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

Cold spray goes organic, and an obsolete part gets printed

FACT: NAVSEA reported on July 16, 2026 that Naval Surface Warfare Center, Crane Division opened its Metal Additive Manufacturing (MADMAN) Repair Center, using low-pressure and high-pressure cold spray to extend the life of naval components. FACT: NSWC Crane Commanding Officer Capt. Rex Boonyobhas is quoted calling it "the first organic industrial base facility for non-structural cold spray within the Navy" and saying it "allows us to shift our focus from 'replace' to 'repair'." FACT: the release states cold spray is a solid-state process that projects metal powder at high speed using compressed gas, that because it does not rely on thermal melting it avoids the cracking and loss of strength fusion welding can introduce, and that the low-pressure systems are portable enough to bring repair capability to the component.

Worth understanding why that matters. Conventional weld repair melts the parent metal, and melting changes it: the heat-affected zone can crack, distort, or lose the temper the part was designed around, which is why some corroded components get condemned rather than repaired. Cold spray never melts anything. Powder hits the surface fast enough to deform and bond mechanically, building material back up while the part stays cool. "Non-structural" is the limit to keep in mind: this restores dimensions and surfaces, not load-bearing strength.

FACT: NAVSEA's Philadelphia division reported on June 11, 2026 that its engineers are using additive manufacturing to redesign and produce the wallbox for the Boiler Combustion Monitoring System, because the existing part is obsolete and no longer available through traditional supply channels. FACT: the release states the system is installed on the Navy's six Wasp-class amphibious assault ships and on USS Blue Ridge (LCC 19), the Seventh Fleet flagship, and that the wallbox gives the furnace camera and inspection light a protected path into the boiler furnace, which boiler operators use to check the furnace deck for unburned fuel before lighting burners, because pooled fuel oil on a hot furnace floor can vaporize into an explosive hazard.

Assessment: these two items sit at opposite ends of the same shift and both convert an engineering capability into a business decision. Crane turns condemnation into a routing question, because components that fusion welding would have risked now have an organic path that did not exist before. Philadelphia is the more common case and the more instructive one: the route to a printed replacement ran through the in-service engineering agent, the organization holding technical authority for that system, not through a print shop. That is the real constraint on most obsolescence lists. Machines are available; the authority to approve a changed design, and the qualification evidence behind it, is what takes the time.

> **Bottom line:** Pull your condemnation data and your top obsolescence drivers into one list, send the first to NSWC Crane to test their intake and throughput, and take the second to the cognizant in-service engineering agent, because that is where the schedule actually lives.

Sources: NAVSEA, Jul 16, 2026; NAVSEA, Jun 11, 2026

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

The interesting part of the RIMPAC demo is the dispatch software, not the printer

FACT: the Navy reported on July 21, 2026 that the Naval Postgraduate School's Consortium for Advanced Manufacturing Research and Education (CAMRE) and FLEETWERX demonstrated a chain during RIMPAC 2026 in which Marines manufactured replacement parts aboard ship using expeditionary advanced manufacturing equipment, a digitally crewed surface vessel carried those components to a US Navy ship, and the delivery completed what the release calls the Department of the Navy's first digitally crewed resupply, after which the same vessel carried drone components ashore to the 25th Infantry Division's Lightning Lab for assembly and testing. FACT: the Navy credits the workflow to the Joint Advanced Manufacturing System (JAMS), a digital command and control platform developed through CAMRE with the Marine Innovation Unit, which tracks manufacturing requests and assigns production across distributed nodes while cataloging equipment, expertise and production capacity across the enterprise. FACT: in a July 7, 2026 release the Navy said CAMRE was preparing what organizers describe as the largest advanced manufacturing demonstration ever conducted by the Department of War, at an exercise involving 35 nations, roughly 40 surface ships, five submarines, more than 140 aircraft and 25,000 personnel.

In plain terms, JAMS is a dispatcher for making things. A unit submits a digital request for a part; the system knows which machines, materials and qualified people exist across a network of military, government, academic, industry and coalition sites; it assigns the job to a node that can actually do it, and tracks it to delivery. The printer is commodity equipment. The catalog of who can make what, to what standard, and the routing decision on top of it, is the thing that does not exist today at scale.

Assessment: this is a watch item rather than an action item, because the equipment was expeditionary, the setting was an exercise, and nothing in the chain passed through a shipyard production or qualification system. What earns attention is the catalog, since a network that inventories production capacity and assigns work across nodes is an allocation mechanism, and allocation mechanisms eventually decide who gets work. Two questions decide whether an industrial-base activity becomes a node: who holds qualification authority for a part made somewhere new, and who owns the technical data package. A demonstration answers neither.

> **Bottom line:** Track JAMS rather than the printers, specifically whether its catalog is ever extended to organic industrial-base shops, because that is the moment this stops being a technology story and becomes a workload one.

Sources: Navy.mil, Jul 21, 2026; Navy.mil, Jul 7, 2026

BUSINESS PRACTICES & STRATEGY

The House just rewrote federal maritime law, and attached it to the defense bill

FACT: the law firm K&L Gates reported on July 24, 2026 that the House passed the FY27 National Defense Authorization Act (H.R. 8800) on July 22 by a vote of 216 to 212, and adopted two maritime amendments that together represent the most significant overhaul of federal maritime law in decades, covering cargo preference, shipbuilding finance, maritime governance, vessel and cargo security, workforce development, and Coast Guard procurement. FACT: per that analysis, the amendment led by House Seapower Subcommittee Chair Trent Kelly, the "Shipbuilding and Harbor Infrastructure for Prosperity and Security for America Act of 2026," runs roughly 100 sections across seven subtitles; creates a maritime security advisor inside the Executive Office of the President; establishes a Maritime Security Trust Fund capped at

$20 billion, without specifying an initial funding mechanism; raises the government cargo preference threshold from 50 percent to 100 percent and creates a “Ship America Office” within MARAD; and establishes a “Shipbuilding Financial Incentives” grant program funding vessel construction and qualified shipyard or supplier investment, with Buy America restrictions attached.

FACT: as dated context, Rep. Joe Courtney said at the June 4, 2026 committee markup that the bill authorizes 21 new vessels, adopts multi-year procurement with fixed-price contracts for up to 15 Arleigh Burke destroyers and multiple John Lewis-class oilers, provides authority for incremental funding of Virginia-class long-lead items to blunt the effect of continuing resolutions, and initiates serial production of the Columbia class with $10 billion for procurement and $5 billion for advance purchase of long-lead items.

Two mechanics are worth being precise about. Cargo preference is the rule requiring government-financed cargo to move on US-flag ships; raising it from 50 to 100 percent increases the demand for US-flag hulls, and hulls eventually need repair. And an authorization is not an appropriation: this bill sets policy and ceilings, the money arrives separately, and the Senate has not acted yet.

Assessment: for anyone in ship repair the operative provisions are not the headline governance ones. A trust fund with a $20 billion cap and no funding mechanism is an empty vessel until appropriators fill it, and a White House maritime advisor changes who convenes meetings. The grant program and the cargo-preference change are the ones with a mechanism attached, because the first puts capital directly into yard and supplier investment and the second raises the baseline demand for US-flag tonnage. Multi-year procurement matters for a different reason: it is the instrument that lets suppliers invest in capacity, and supplier capacity is the constraint that shows up in your availabilities as late material.

Assessment: hold this next to the reorganization thread this brief covered last week, when the Navy’s Portfolio Acquisition Executive for Maritime reached initial operating capability and a separate PAE Industrial Operations took maintenance and the public shipyards (USNI News, July 20, 2026). Nothing further was published this week on the industrial operations half, so that thread is open rather than advancing, but Congress and the Navy are now restructuring how ships get bought and sustained at the same time, and both efforts land on the same program offices.

> **Bottom line:** Read the Senate’s version when it appears against three questions: whether the trust fund gets an actual funding stream, whether the grant program is open to repair yards and their suppliers or only to builders, and whether the multi-year authorities survive.

Sources: K&L Gates, Jul 24, 2026; Rep. Joe Courtney, Jun 4, 2026; USNI News, Jul 20, 2026

$76.6 billion in submarines, read as a workload and supplier forecast

FACT: USNI News reported on July 29, 2026 that the Navy awarded General Dynamics Electric Boat and HII $76.6 billion after a delay of nearly three years, split into $42.1 billion for nine Block VI Virginia-class boats plus material for a tenth, $29.5 billion for five Build II Columbia-class boats, and $5 billion for workforce improvements, and that the Pentagon announcement states the Block VI award includes previously announced material awards, including long-lead-time and economic ordering quantity material.

Assessment: the dollar figure is the least useful number here. Economic ordering quantity means the builders buy components in bulk, years early, to hold a price, and they draw from the same vendor base that supplies repair availabilities, so this award reaches a repair schedule as material lead times rather than as a headline. Fourteen new hulls also become depot workload on a delivery-plus-years horizon, which makes the delivery schedule, not the award value, the artifact worth having in a long-range plan.

> **Bottom line:** Ask your supply chain which long-lead components overlap with the submarine build plan, because that overlap is where this award reaches your availabilities first.

Sources: USNI News, Jul 29, 2026

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault's research engine from NAVSEA and Navy releases, DVIDS, USNI News, Naval News, GAO and congressional records, defense.gov, RAND, Defense News, Breaking Defense, The Maritime Executive, NSRP, ASNE, SNAME, arXiv, and academic publishers (23 sources staged this week; 14 quarantined as stale, including a SIOP story a search engine dated to this month that its own page dates to September 2024), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and INDOPACOM partners. Freshness policy: every article's anchor source is under 12 months old; this issue's anchors run from two days to eight weeks old, and older material appears only as clearly dated context. FACT means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it; Assessment is analysis built only on facts stated above it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	NSRP Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Cvent link open)	The panel behind the fiber-optic switchboard-sensing pilot; electrical condition-monitoring tech transfer
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Pensacola, FL	**In-person closes Aug 13, 2026**	Cross-yard workforce practices against the Navy's 250,000-hire target
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium (FMMS) 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	**Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026**	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this readership
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	SCA Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and VCM-era procurement priorities, with contracting-officer access
Dec 7-9, 2026	TSS/CSS Symposium, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology, systems and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit (MILAM), Tampa, FL	Tiers: Jul 31 / Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and NAVSEA-spec adoption
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide
Apr 12-15, 2027	RAPID + TCT 2027, Detroit, MI (SME)	None published	The largest additive show in North America; the market read behind the Danville AM pipeline
Jun 7-9, 2027	MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE)	Not open yet per ASNE	The Navy corrosion event; preservation is a top waterfront cost driver

Beyond the printed window: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027). Two additive events sit on the registry without published dates and will print when the organizers set them: the annual ATDM and AM CoE Summit in Danville, and the next Defense Manufacturing Conference.